

Money Also Can't Buy This

Before we move on to the tangible things, let's talk about one more intangible.

I (Jen) have got a lot to thank Kim Kardashian for.

When *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* premiered in 2007, having curves was not cool. However, by the time I'd graduated college, Kim had made a delicious derriere the hot thing to have. People were buying glute-focused workout routines, butt-beautifying products, and pants designed to give the optical illusion of a butt. Not me. I am naturally blessed. And in my early twenties, I needed something about my body to be proud of.

Because my entire life I'd been told I was overweight. I was big around the hips, not naturally athletic, and definitely not the ideal of late '90s/early 2000s physique. With two low-income working parents, my family didn't have a lot of money or the time needed to prepare healthy foods, and even if they did, their parents never taught them how or knew it was important themselves. My parents wouldn't directly tell me I was fat, it was always phrased as "We need to lose some weight." They projected their insecurities on me, and I internalized them. My mom would buy diet pills and whatever the newest "As seen on TV" diet fad was, but all I got was my pediatrician telling my mom to stop giving me whole milk. Toward the end of college, I decided to do something about it. I started running. I ran a half marathon, and once I got a full-time job and some disposable income, I joined CrossFit. I started to fall in love with what my body could do, but I never stopped feeling insecure about it. I was in a good place for a while, then I had kids. My body supported the growth of two human beings, delivered them safely, and then had the nerve to not return to the shape from whence it came. I felt betrayed. I wish, after two healthy babies and six half marathons, I could say I've worked through my body issues, but I'm not there yet. I am still scrolling fitness accounts on social media with "before and after" shots. For me it's always a before, never an after. And no matter how much money I've spent to feel good about my body, it's never been enough. I've never been able to buy that love, and neither can you. But it doesn't stop many of us from trying.

In 2022, the US weight-loss market was valued at \$135.7 billion. Every year Americans' spending on supplements, meal replacements, fitness equipment, weight-loss programs, and surgical procedures like liposuction